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The Complete Book of Self-Sufficiency

John Seymour

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The Complete Book of

Self-Sufficiency

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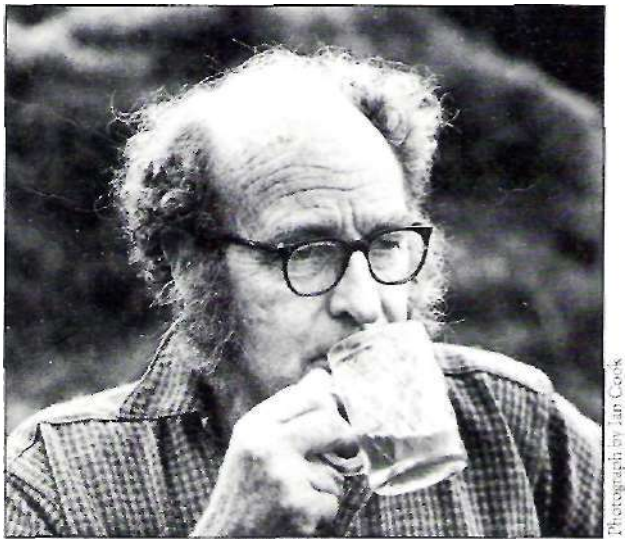
The Complete Book of

Self-Sufficiency

John Seymour

With a foreword by E. F. Schumacher
author of 'Small is Beautiful'

John Seymour was educated in England and Switzerland. After studying at an agricultural college, he worked on farms in England for two years and then spent some ten years in Africa where, among other things, he managed a sheep and cattle farm and acted as a livestock officer for a government veterinary department. After service in the King's African Rifles in the war, he travelled widely, lived on a fishing boat, wrote, broadcast, and studied the way of lite of rural people. Then, with his wife Sally, he settled down to running a self-sufficient smallholding in Suffolk, where he developed many, of the skills described in this book. Alter eight years in Suffolk they moved to Pembrokeshire, and a 62-acre farm. John Seymour has now remarried, and the farm is being developed as a school in the arts of self-sufficiency. The aim of the people on the farm is to endeavour to bring self-reliance, self-respect, people, culture and fun back to the countryside.



Photograph by Jan Cook

The Complete Book of Self-Sufficiency is a book for all seasons. Whether you live in town or country, on a farm or in a cottage, in a house with a garden or a flat with a window-box, this book has something for you.

If you want to
bake your own bread, brew your own beer, make your own cheese, pickle your own onions, this book will show you how.

If you want to
make hay, milk a cow, smoke a ham, design a dairy, convert to solar energy, this book will show you how.

If you just want to
grow your own vegetables, bottle your own fruit, dry your own herbs, this book will demonstrate exactly what to do.

The Complete Book of Self Sufficiency is an invaluable manual, packed with illustrations, and every illustration tells its own story, shows you what you need and how to do it.

John Seymour is everywhere recognised as *the* expert in self-sufficiency. He has lived the life for twenty years, and here he gathers all the expertise he has acquired into one authoritative volume.

The Complete Book of Self Sufficiency covers the whole range of the self-sufficient spectrum. It describes how, according to the size of your plot, *you can plan to support yourself, grow your own crops, keep your own livestock. It helps you over all the hurdles of growing and preserving your own food,* whether you harvest straight from the field or from the garden, from animals or from the wild. John Seymour guides you through every stage of the cycle. He shows you how to plant your crop, tend it, harvest it, preserve it, process it, and finally, how to cook it - in a variety of ways. He also includes chapters on how you can produce your own energy, and how you can help to re-vitalise many of the near-forgotten crafts.

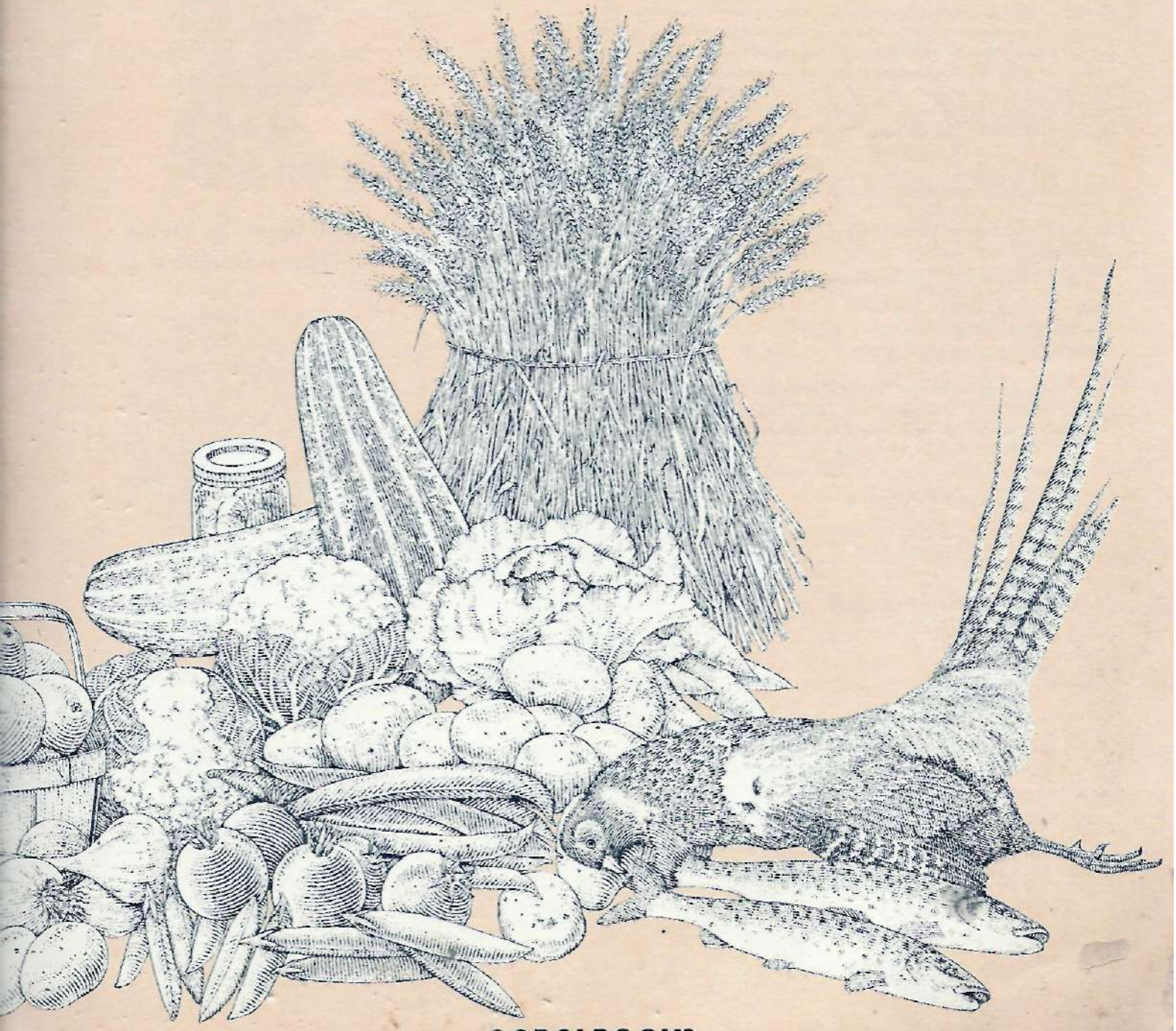
This is the first totally comprehensive book on supporting yourself. It is an encyclopaedia of practical advice on how to attain the skills and enjoy the fruits of the self-sufficient way of life.

See inside back cover
for press comments about this book.

The Complete Book of Self-Sufficiency

John Seymour

Foreword by E.F. Schumacher



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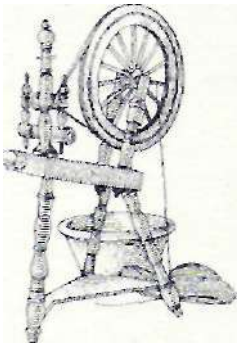

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FOREWORD

We can do things for ourselves or we can pay others to do them for us. These are the two "systems" that support us; we might call them the "self-reliance system" and the "organization system". The former tends to breed self-reliant men and women; the latter tends to produce organization men and women. All existing societies support themselves by a mixture of the two systems; but the proportions Vary.

In the modern world, during the last hundred years or so, there has been an enormous and historically unique shift: away from self-reliance and towards organization. As a result people are becoming less self-reliant and more dependent than has ever been seen in history. They may claim to be more highly educated than any generation before them; but the fact remains that they cannot really do anything for themselves. They depend utterly on vastly complex organizations, on fantastic machinery, on larger and larger money incomes. What if there is a hold-up, a breakdown, a strike, or unemployment? Does the state provide all that is needed? In some cases, yes; in other cases, no. Many people fall through the meshes of the safety net; and what then? They suffer; they become dispirited, even despondent. Why can't they help themselves? Generally, the answer is only too obvious: they would not know how to; they have never done it before and would not even know where to begin.

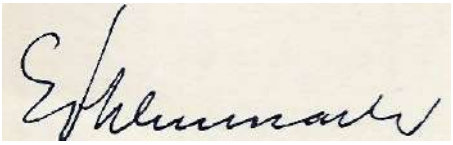
John Seymour can tell us how *to* help ourselves, and in this book he does tell us. He is one of the great pioneers of self-sufficiency. Pioneers are not for imitation but for learning from. Should we all do what John Seymour has done and is doing? Of course not. Total self-sufficiency is as unbalanced and ultimately stultifying as total organization. The pioneers show us what *can* be done, and it is for every one of us to decide what *should* be done, that is to say, what *we* should do to restore some kind of balance to our existence.

Should I try to grow *all* the food my family and I require? If I tried to do so, I probably could do little else. And what about all the other things we need? Should I try to become a Jack of all trades? At most of these trades I would be pretty incompetent and horribly inefficient. But to grow or make *some* things by myself, for myself: what fun, what exhilaration, what liberation from any feelings of utter dependence on organizations! What is perhaps even more: what an education of the real person! To be in touch with *actual processes of creation.* The inborn creativity of people is no mean or accidental thing; neglect or disregard it, and it becomes an inner source of poison. It can destroy you and all your human relationships; on a mass scale, it can - nay, it inevitably will - destroy society.

Contrariwise, nothing can stop the flowering of a society that manages to give free rein to the creativity of its people - *all* its people. This cannot be ordered and organized from the top. We cannot look to government, but only to ourselves, to bring about such a state of affairs. Nor should anyone of us go on "waiting for Godot" because Godot never comes. It is interesting to think of all the "Godots" modern humanity is waiting for: this or that fantastic technical breakthrough; colossal new discoveries of oil and gasfields; automation so that nobody - or hardly anybody - will have to lift a finger any more; government policies to solve all problems once and for all: multinational companies to make massive investments in the latest and best technology; or simply "the next upturn of the economy".

John Seymour has never been found "waiting for Godot". It is the essence of self-reliance that you start now and don't wait for something to turn up.

The technology behind John Seymour's self-sufficiency is still quite rudimentary and can of course be improved. The greater the number of practitioners the faster will be the rate of improvement, that is, the creation of technologies designed to lead people to self-reliance, work-enjoyment, creativity, and therefore: *the good life.* This book is a major step along that road, and I wholeheartedly commend it to you,



DR. E.F. SCHUMACHER, CBE

The Way to Self - Sufficiency

The first questions we must answer are: What is this book about? What is self-sufficiency, and why do it?

Now self-sufficiency is not "going back" to some idealized past in which people grubbed for their food with primitive implements and burned each other for witchcraft. It is going *forward* to a new and better sort of life, a life which is more fun than the over-specialized round of office or factory, a life that brings challenge and the use of daily initiative back to work, and variety, and occasional great success and occasional abysmal failure. It means the acceptance of complete responsibility for what you do or what you do not do, and one of its greatest rewards is the joy that comes from seeing each job right through - from sowing your own wheat to eating your own bread, from planting a field of pig food to slicing a side of bacon.

Self-sufficiency does not mean "going back" to the acceptance of a lower standard of living. On the contrary, it is the striving for a higher standard of living, for food which is fresh and organically-grown and good, for the good life in pleasant surroundings, for the health of body and peace of mind which come with hard varied work in the open air, and for the satisfaction that comes from doing difficult and intricate jobs well and successfully.

A further preoccupation of the self-sufficient person should be the correct attitude to the land. If it ever comes to pass that we have used up all, or most of, the oil on this planet, we will have to reconsider our attitude to our only real and abiding asset - the land itself. We will one day have to derive our sustenance from what the land, unaided by oil-derived chemicals, can produce. We may not wish in the future to maintain a standard of living that depends entirely on elaborate and expensive equipment and machinery but we will always want to maintain a high standard of living in the things that really matter-good food, clothing, shelter, health, happiness, and fun with other people. The land *can* support us, and it can do it without huge applications of artificial chemicals and manures and the use of expensive machinery. But everyone who owns a piece of land should husband that land as wisely, knowledgeably, and intensively as possible. The so-called-"self-supporter" sitting among a riot of docks and thistles talking philosophy ought to go back to town. He is not doing any good at all, and is occupying land which should be occupied by somebody who can really use it.

Other forms of life, too, besides our own, should merit our consideration. Man should be a husbandman, not an exploiter. This planet is not exclusively for our own use. To destroy every form of life except such forms as are obviously directly of use to us is immoral, and ultimately quite possibly, will contribute to our own destruction. The kind of varied, carefully thought-out, husbandry of the self-supporting holding fosters a great variety of life forms, and every self-supporter will wish to leave some areas of true wilderness on his holding, where wild forms of life can continue to flourish undisturbed and in peace.

And then there is the question of our relations with other people. Many people move from the cities back to the land precisely because they find city life, surrounded by people, too lonely. A self-supporter, living alone surrounded by giant commercial farms, may be lonely too; but if he has other self-supporters near him he will be forced into cooperation with them and find himself, very quickly, part of a living and warm community. There will be shared work in the fields, there will be relief milking and animal feeding duties when other people go on holiday, the sharing of child minding duties, there will be barn-raisings and corn-shuckings and celebrations of all kinds. This kind of social life is already beginning in those parts of Europe and North America w-here self-supporting individuals, or communities, are becoming common.

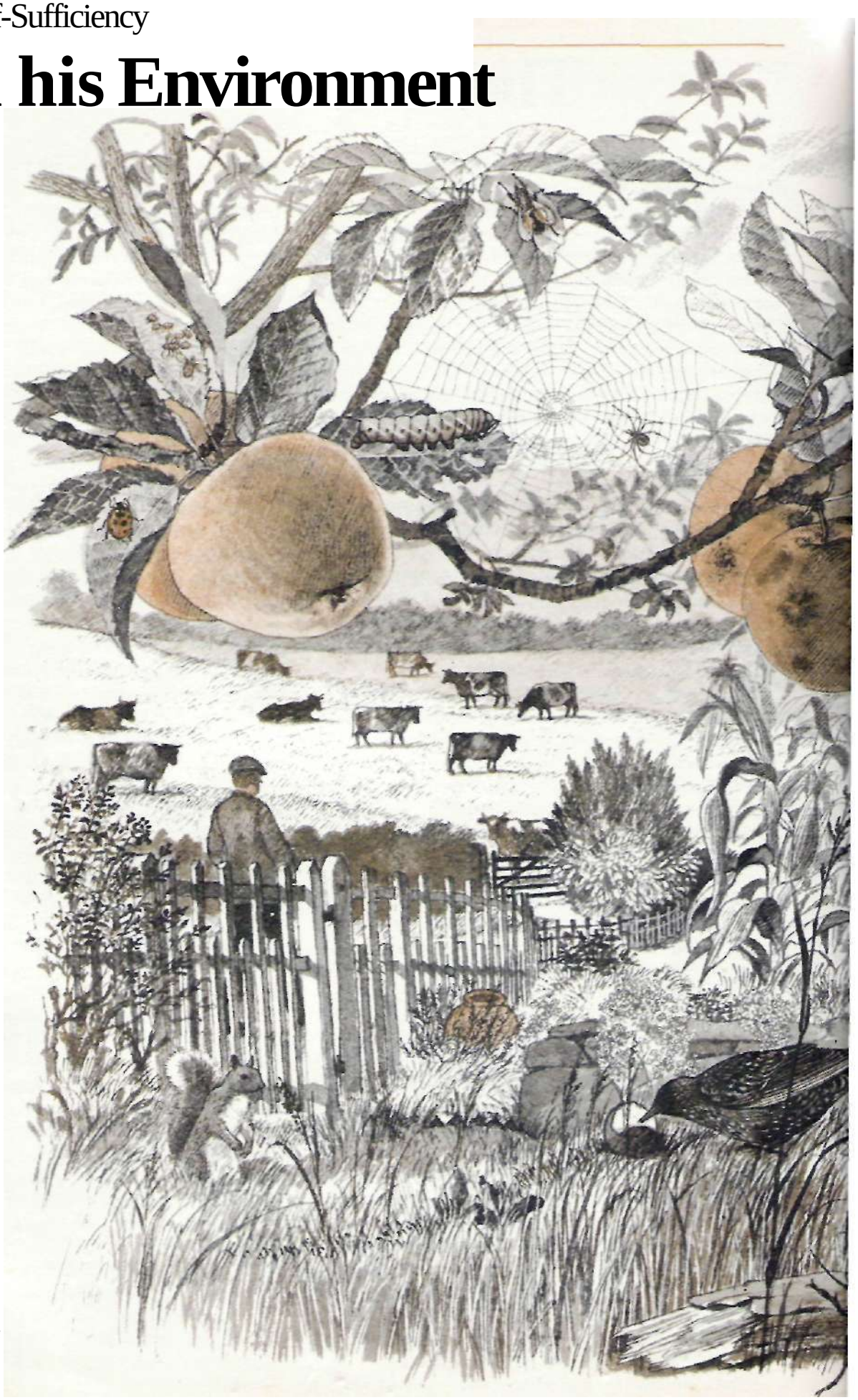
Good relations with the old indigenous population of the countryside are important too. In my area, the old country people are very sympathetic to the new "drop-ins'.' They rejoice to see us reviving and preserving the old skills they practised in their youth and they take pleasure in imparting them to us. They wax eloquent when they see the hams and flitches of bacon hung up in my chimney. "That's *real* bacon!" they say. "Better than the stuff we get in the shops. My mother used to make that when I was a boy - we grew all our own food then" "Why don't you grow it now?" I ask. "Ah - times have changed'.' Well, they are changing again.

Self-sufficiency is not only for those who have five acres of their own country. The man in a city apartment who learns how[7] to mend his own shoes is becoming, to some extent, self-sufficient. Not only does he save money, he increases his own satisfaction and self-respect too. Man was not *meant to* be a one-job animal. We do not thrive as parts of a machine. We are intended by nature to be diverse, to do diverse things, to have many skills. The city person who buys a sack of wheat from a farmer on a visit to the country-side and grinds his own flour to make his own bread cuts out a lot of middle men and furthermore gets better bread. He gets good exercise turning the handle of the grinding machine too. And any suburban gardener can dig up some of that useless lawn and put some of those dreary hardy perennials on the compost heap and grow his own cabbages. A good sized suburban garden can practically keep a family. I knew a woman who grew the finest outdoor tomatoes I ever saw in a window-box twelve storeys up in a tower-block. They were too high up to get the blight.

So good luck and long life to all self supporters! And if every reader of this book learns something useful to him that he did not know before, and could not very easily find out, then I shall be happy and feel that the hard work that not only I as author have put into it, but also the hard-working and dedicated people who have done the very arduous and difficult work of putting it together, and illustrating it, have not worked in vain.

The Way to Self-Sufficiency

Man & his Environment



The *true* homesteader *will seek to husband his land, not exploit it. He will wish to improve and maintain the "heart" of his land, its fertility. He will learn by observing nature that growing one crop only, or keeping one species of animal only, on the same piece of land is not in the natural order of things. He will therefore wish to nurture the animals and plants on his land to ensure the survival of the widest possible variety of natural forms. He will understand and encourage the interaction between them. He will even leave some areas of wilderness on his land, where wild forms of life can flourish. Where he cultivates he will always keep in mind the needs of his soil, considering each animal and each plant for what beneficial effect it might have on the land. Above all, he will realize that if he interferes with the chain of life (of which he is a part) he does so at his peril, for he cannot avoid disturbing a natural balance.*

The Way to Self-Sufficiency

THE FIRST PRINCIPLES OF SELF-SUFFICIENCY

The only way that the homesteader can farm his piece of land as well and intensively as possible is to institute some variant of what was called "High Farming" in Europe in the last century. This was a carefully worked out balance between animals and plants, so that each fed the other: the plants feeding the animals directly, the animals feeding the soil with their manure and the land feeding the plants. A variety of both animals and plants were rotated about the same land so that each species took what it needed out and put what it had to contribute back, and the needs of the soil were kept uppermost always in the husbandman's mind. Each animal and crop was considered for what beneficial effect it might have on the soil.

If the same crop is grown on a piece of land year after year the disease organisms that attack that crop will build up in the area until they become uncontrollable. Nature abhors monoculture: any cursory inspection of a natural plant and animal environment will reveal a great variety of species. If one species becomes too predominant some pest or disease is sure to develop to strike it down. Man has managed to defy this law, to date, by the application of stronger and stronger chemical controls, but the pests (particularly the fast-evolving viruses) adapt very quickly to withstand each new chemical and to date the chemist has managed to keep only a short jump ahead of the disease.

The new homesteader will wish to husband his land in accordance with the principles of High Farming. He will have to substitute the labour of his hands for imported chemicals and sophisticated machinery. He will have to use his brain and his cunning to save the work of his hands. For instance, if he can get his animals to go out into his fields and consume their share of his crops there, then he will save himself the work of harvesting the crops for them and carrying them in. In other words, take the animals to the crops, not the crops to the animals. So also, if he can get the animals to deposit their dung on his land, then this will save him the labour of carrying the dung out himself. Thus the keeping of animals on limited free range will appeal to him: sheep can be "folded" on arable land (folding means penning animals on a small area of some fodder crop and moving the pen from time to time), chickens can be housed in arks that can be moved over the land so as to distribute the hens' manure while allowing the hens to graze fresh grass, and pigs can be kept behind electric fences which can also be easily moved. Thus the pigs harvest their food for themselves and also distribute their own manure. (To say nothing of the fact that pigs are the finest free cultivators that were ever invented! They will clear your land, and plough it, and dung it, and harrow it, and leave it nearly ready for you to put your seed in, with no more labour to you than the occasional shifting of an electric fence.)

Now the true husbandman will not keep the same species of animal on a piece of land too long, just as he will not grow the same crop year after year in the same place. He will follow his young calves with his older cattle, his cattle with sheep, his sheep with horses, while geese and other poultry either run free or are progressively moved over his grassland and arable (arable means land that gets ploughed and planted with crops as opposed to land that is grass all the time). All animals suffer from parasites and if you keep one species on one piece of land for too long there will be a build-up of parasites and disease organisms. As a rule the parasites of one animal do not affect another and therefore following one species with another over the land will eliminate parasites.

Also, the true husbandman will find that every enterprise on his holding, if it is correctly planned, will interact beneficially with every other. If he keeps cows their dung will manure the land which will provide food, not only for the cows, but for the humans and pigs also. The by-products of the milk of the cows (skimmed milk from butter making and whey from cheese making) are a marvellous whole food for pigs and poultry. The dung from the pigs and poultry helps grow the food for the cows. Chickens will scratch about in the dung of other animals and will salvage any undigested grain.

All crop residues help to feed the appropriate animals - and such residues as not even the pigs can eat they will tread into the ground, and activate with their manure, and turn into the finest *in situ* compost without the husbandman lifting a spade. All residues from slaughtered birds or animals go either to feed the pigs, .or the sheep dogs, or to activate the compost heap. Nothing is wasted. Nothing is an expensive embarrassment to be taken away to pollute the environment. There should be no need of a dustman on the self-sufficient holding. Even old newspapers can make litter for pigs, or be composted. Anything that has to be burnt makes good potash for the land. Nothing is wasted- there is no "rubbish'.'

But before the potential self-supporter embarks on the pursuit of "true husbandry" he should acquaint himself with some of the basic laws of nature, so that he can better understand why certain things will happen on his holding and why other things will not.

THE FOOD CHAIN

Life on this planet has been likened to a pyramid: a pyramid with an unbelievably wide base and a small apex.

All life needs nitrogen, for it is one of the most essential constituents of living matter, but most creatures cannot use the free, uncombined, nitrogen which makes up a great part of our atmosphere. The base of our biotic pyramid, therefore, is made up of the bacteria that live in the soil, sometimes in symbiosis with higher plants, and have the power of fixing nitrogen from the air. The number of these organisms in